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From the editor-in-chief

Stardom, as most in the film industry know, is an elusive quality. There is no telling what makes a star. Some are one-movie wonders, some last a little longer and the rare ones are everlasting. As the rewards of stardom are so great, there is an endless stream of aspirants who are ground to dust in the Bollywood factory and only a few make it. Once in a while, the Bollywood firmament is lit up by an actor who has both star quality and real talent.

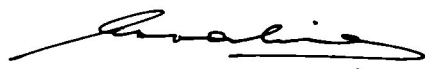
This is one of those times. We are seeing the evolution of a young actor who is not many films old but has Bollywood abuzz with directors talking about his versatile talent. That actor is the 27-year-old Ranbir Kapoor. He comes from a great pedigree and obviously got a headstart but so have many others who have failed to make it. Kapoor is heir to a great Bollywood dynasty. Great grandson of Prithviraj, the founder of Prithvi Theatres, grandson of director-actor Raj, grand-nephew to the irrepressible, iconic Shammi and workhorse Shashi and son of the charming romantic hero Rishi. That is not an easy legacy to live with. Kapoor is, however, living up to his family's reputation. In his brief film career, he has done enough to convince his audience that he is here to stay.

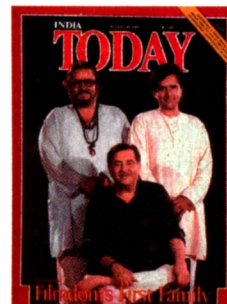
Yet, unlike what normally happens in Bollywood, Kapoor wears his family name lightly today. As an actor, he is confidently hitting his stride at a time when our film industry is experimenting with different subjects and newer forms. Kapoor came into his own playing the central character in the political drama *Raajneeti*, his latest film. It marked a complete change from his past roles, which while actually varied, typecast him somewhat in public memory as a one-dimensional chocolate boy. In the last three years, Kapoor has been in a smart mix of the far-out comedy *Ajab Prem Ki Ghazab Kahani*, the critical success *Rocket Singh: Salesman of the Year* and the coming of age *Wake Up Sid*, which reflected the new language of India's confused younger generation. In *Raajneeti*, however, he took on the role of the anti-hero, an Arjun/Michael Corleone scion of a political family, and played it with an effortless understated nuance.

He finds himself on the INDIA TODAY cover this week not because he is a Kapoor but because he is very much a GenNext movie star. Our cover story was written by Managing Editor Kaveree Bamzai, who met Kapoor even as *Raajneeti* was sparking debate and making waves. She found him excited about preparing for his next role, where he's teaching himself to play the guitar, and says, "In an industry that suffers from a chronic short attention span, Kapoor knows he is only as good as his last movie."

For over two decades, the Khan triumvirate had set the agenda for the industry but Kapoor is clearly an icon of a new sensibility which needs alternative star vehicles. He is the leader of a pack of young actors—Shahid Kapoor, Imran Khan and Abhay Deol being the others—who are trying hard to not conform to Bollywood's 'filmi' stereotypes.

He told Bamzai that when he joined the film industry he wanted to do four things—shoot in Switzerland, give a Filmfare award speech, do a Pepsi ad and be on INDIA TODAY's cover. Well Ranbir, you've achieved all four now. Don't disappoint us.


(Aroon Purie)



OUR AUGUST 1982 COVER